

The second question dealt with how to preserve wealth when the Four Horsemen are on the loose. Biggs went through a lot of WWII-era carnage to find answers. You'll find such chapter headings and subheads as "Preserving Wealth in a Time of Cholera," "The Plunder of Land in Poland," "The Seizure of Estates in Hungary," "The Theft of Land and Valuables in Czechoslovakia" and "Rape and Robbery by the Red Army."

And yet, after all that, even the catastrophist Biggs recommended putting 75 percent of your wealth in stocks.

This is partly because his own understanding of the history of catastrophes validated such a move — stocks were still often the best way to preserve purchasing power over a period of years, even in devastated Germany. But it is also because he understood the best shot you have at growing your wealth is to own stuff. You want to be an owner.

If you own stocks, you are part owner in a real business — with real people trying to figure things out and with real assets and real profits.

Ownership of assets is your best long-term protection against calamity.

But what to do with the other 25 percent?

Biggs recommended a much smaller part of your wealth go toward a ranch or family farm. He advocated a safe haven, well stocked with seed, fertilizer, canned food, wine, medicines, clothes and so on.

This survivalist stuff is not my main idea. I just want to make the point that in real collapse, your portfolio will probably be among the least of your worries. But at least in a calamity like WWII, stocks were your best bet.

So, let's pull this back to the coffee-can idea and think about a coffee can for catastrophists.

First, your coffee can doesn't have to include stocks. You could, if you were so inclined, stuff your coffee can with gold. I wouldn't do that, but the point is the coffee-can idea is not an expression of Buffett-like optimism on America. You could put whatever you want in your coffee can.

The essence of the coffee-can idea is really that it's a way to protect you against yourself — from the emotions and volatility that make you buy or sell at the wrong times. Bullishness or bearishness doesn't enter